ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

Student Budgeting and Saving: Make Your Allowance Last the Month

A simple budget you can keep on your phone, and rules for spending decisions

MONEY & CAREER

Money & Career

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Running out of money mid-month is usually a planning problem rather than an income problem. This pack shows you how to track spending for one week, build a realistic monthly budget, separate needs from wants, and create a small emergency fund without pretending rice is optional.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Track actual spending and identify waste without guilt.
- Build a monthly budget based on real categories and costs.
- Apply a rule for separating needs, wants and emergencies.
- Start a modest emergency fund and avoid predatory borrowing.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Know where the money goes

You cannot budget what you have not measured. Track for seven days before changing anything.

- Record every payment, including small transport and data top-ups.
- Group spending into food, transport, data, accommodation, academic materials, social and other.
- Compare planned and actual totals at the end of the week.
- Find the leak categories: often snacks, unplanned outings and duplicate data bundles.
- Keep tracking for a month before making big changes.
- A notebook works; a spreadsheet or notes app works too.

Build the budget

A budget is a plan for money you have, not a wish list.

1. Estimate total monthly income: allowance, support, side income.
2. Put fixed costs first: rent, transport, feeding, data, academic materials.
3. Set a realistic food figure using actual meal costs, not wishful numbers.
4. Allocate a small social and discretionary amount deliberately.
5. Set aside a fixed amount for savings and emergencies before spending.
6. Adjust after the first month using real data, not optimism.

> **Pay yourself first**
> Move the savings amount out of the spending account at the start of the month. What remains is the budget; savings are not what is left over.

Saving and borrowing rules

Small, consistent savings beat occasional large intentions.

- Aim for a small buffer that covers transport, food and one unexpected cost.
- Use a separate account or wallet so the money is less visible.
- Never borrow to fund a want; borrow only for a genuine emergency.
- Avoid loan apps with short tenors and extreme fees.
- Never guarantee a loan for a friend or share your account details.
- Review your budget monthly and keep one record of what worked.

Where the money actually goes

Almost every student who says money disappears without knowing where is right: it does disappear, but not without a pattern. Track every naira for four weeks - notes or a simple spreadsheet - and the pattern appears within a fortnight. Until you have data, a budget is a wish.

Student spending concentrates in four places: food, transport, data and social. The last is the one people underestimate, because it arrives in small amounts and is hard to refuse. Naming it is the first step to controlling it.

Set a weekly figure rather than a monthly one. A monthly allowance is usually exhausted by day ten because the first week absorbs setup costs and the second absorbs social pressure. Weekly limits are easier to hold and easier to correct.

Budgeting that survives a lump sum

Most Nigerian students receive money in irregular amounts - a semester allowance, a transfer from a relative, occasional earnings. Budgeting for irregular income means building three envelopes: fixed costs (rent, fees), variable essentials (food, transport, data), and a buffer. The buffer is the line that prevents a small shock from becoming a crisis.

Pay yourself first. Move a fixed amount into a separate account or a locked savings arrangement on the day money arrives, before spending becomes possible. Saving what remains at the end of the month is not a strategy; nothing remains.

Buy in bulk with people you trust for staples, cook rather than buy prepared food, and treat transport as a planning problem - walking distance and route choice matter more than fare negotiation.

> **The 24-hour rule**
> For any non-essential purchase above a level you decide in advance, wait a day. Most wants do not survive the wait, and the ones that do are usually worth buying.

Debt, emergencies and talking about money

Avoid borrowing for consumption. Borrowing for an examination fee or a medical cost is different from borrowing to attend a party, and the difference is whether the cost is unavoidable. If you must borrow, write the amount and repayment date, and tell the lender when you will pay.

An emergency fund of even a small amount changes behaviour: it removes the panic that produces bad decisions. Start with an amount that covers transport and food for one week, then grow it.

Money is uncomfortable to discuss, which is exactly why students get exploited. Compare prices, ask what a service includes, refuse to pay for anything you have not understood, and share information with classmates about who charges what. A group that talks about prices is a group that gets overcharged less.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Building a weekly budget from data

After four weeks of tracking you find: food 18,000, transport 8,000, data 5,000, social 12,000, other 4,000. You receive 45,000 a month.

1. Total spending is 47,000, so you are overspending by 2,000.
2. Identify the flexible category: social at 12,000 is the largest avoidable item.
3. Set a weekly cap for social rather than a monthly one.
4. Reduce food cost by cooking two more meals weekly.
5. Move 3,000 to savings on receipt day.
6. Recheck after two weeks and adjust the cap rather than abandoning the plan.

> **What to carry forward**
> Cut from the flexible category, not from the one that keeps you alive.

2. Handling an unexpected cost

A 9,000 naira medical bill arrives mid-month with 5,000 left.

1. Treat it as essential and pay it.
2. Do not borrow from a high-interest lender for the difference.
3. Reduce the flexible categories for the remaining days.
4. Ask about a payment plan or student health scheme at the clinic.
5. Record the shortfall and rebuild the buffer next month.
6. Ask whether an equivalent future cost could be avoided.

> **What to carry forward**
> Pay essentials, cut flexibles, avoid expensive debt, rebuild the buffer.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Why is a weekly budget more effective than a monthly one for students?

10 marks

1. Monthly allowances are exhausted early by setup and social costs.
2. Weekly limits allow correction within the month.
3. Shorter horizons make spending visible and controllable.

Q2. Explain the purpose of an emergency buffer and how to build one on a small allowance.

15 marks

1. Define the buffer and the panic it prevents.
2. Start with one week's essential costs.
3. Save on receipt day rather than at month end.
4. Keep it separate from spending money.
5. Rebuild after use.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Budget. A plan allocating expected income to intended spending and saving.

Fixed cost. A cost that does not vary with day-to-day choices, such as rent.

Variable cost. A cost that changes with behaviour, such as food and transport.

Buffer. Money reserved to absorb unexpected costs.

Pay yourself first. Saving a set amount immediately on receiving income.

Consumption debt. Borrowing to buy things that are used up rather than invested.

Tracking. Recording actual spending to reveal patterns.

Sinking fund. Regular saving towards a known future expense.

Opportunity cost. What you give up by choosing one use of money over another.

Liquidity. How quickly an asset can be turned into cash without loss.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Track

Data.

- Record every expense for seven days.
- Total by category.
- Identify the largest flexible cost.

Week 2 - Plan

Limits.

- Set a weekly figure for each category.
- Move savings on receipt day.
- Start a one-week buffer.

Week 3 - Cut

Choices.

- Apply the 24-hour rule twice.
- Cook two extra meals weekly.
- Compare prices for one regular purchase.

Week 4 - Review

Adjust.

- Compare plan with actuals.
- Adjust one category only.
- Write down the emergency plan.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- A personal finance guide for students.
- Your institution's fees and payment schedule.
- A budgeting spreadsheet or app tutorial.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Why track spending before budgeting?

Answer: Actual data reveals real costs and leaks; budgets built on guesses usually fail in week two.

2. What is 'pay yourself first'?

Answer: Setting aside savings at the start of the month before discretionary spending begins.

3. Give two examples of want disguised as need.

Answer: A second pair of fashionable shoes and an upgraded phone when the current one works.

4. Why are short-tenor loan apps risky?

Answer: They often carry very high fees and penalties, and easy access encourages borrowing for non-essential spending.

5. What should an emergency fund cover?

Answer: Unexpected costs such as medical treatment, emergency transport or replacing a lost essential item.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Track every expense for seven days.
- [ ] Categorise spending and find three leaks.
- [ ] Build a monthly budget with fixed and variable costs.
- [ ] Open a separate savings wallet or account.
- [ ] Set a fixed monthly savings amount.
- [ ] Review the month honestly and adjust one category.
- [ ] Write a personal rule for borrowing.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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